

RFC-Conformant HTTP Normalization to Defeat Mutation-Based SQL Injection Bypass

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Abstract—Web application firewalls (WAFs) are widely deployed to detect and block malicious inputs, yet mutation-based payload obfuscation can still evade signature-based rules. A key contributor is the existence of parsing discrepancies: the same HTTP request may be interpreted differently by the WAF and the backend application due to differences in HTTP message processing, Content-Type handling, or ambiguous encodings. This work proposes a preprocessing-based defense that enforces deterministic, RFC-compliant HTTP normalization before inspection. We design an HTTP-Normalizer proxy that removes optional ambiguities, canonicalizes message components according to their corresponding standards, and rejects malformed requests to ensure consistent downstream interpretation.

We evaluate the effectiveness of the approach in a pipeline of *Fuzzer* $\rightarrow$ *WAF* $\rightarrow$ *Application*. Thousands of mutation-based SQL injection payloads are generated and tested across multiple Content-Types, including ‘multipart/form-data’, ‘application/json’, and ‘application/xml’. The benchmark compares the WAF bypass rate without normalization against the bypass rate after normalization, and we further categorize remaining bypasses by the underlying discrepancy mechanism. The results indicate that RFC-based normalization substantially reduces bypass success while limiting residual gaps to non-conformant client behaviors. Finally, we analyze the security-performance trade-off of strict normalization and discuss deployment considerations.

Index Terms—Web application firewall, HTTP request normalization, parsing discrepancies, mutation-based SQL injection, RFC compliance

I. INTRODUCTION

Web applications have become the dominant interface for e-commerce, identity management, and data-driven services. To mitigate common injection and exploitation attempts, many deployments rely on Web Application Firewalls (WAFs) that inspect inbound traffic and block requests that match known attack patterns. In practice, WAFs are often configured using rule-based signatures and curated detection logic, including collections aligned with OWASP guidance [?], [?].

Despite their prevalence, WAF effectiveness against modern attackers remains challenging. First, traditional payload obfuscation techniques that were historically useful for bypassing static signatures are increasingly detected as defenders improve normalization and detection coverage [?]. Second, even when the WAF blocks a large fraction of mutated inputs, parsing discrepancies between the WAF and the backend application can still be exploited. The same HTTP message can be interpreted differently due to differences in how Content-

Type values are parsed, how encodings are resolved, and how multipart or structured bodies are tokenized [?], [?]. As a result, an attacker may craft a request that appears benign under the WAF’s interpretation while retaining an injection-relevant representation when processed by the application.

This paper proposes a preprocessing-based defense that performs HTTP normalization before the request reaches the WAF and application processing logic. The key idea is to eliminate representational degrees of freedom by enforcing deterministic, RFC-compliant message handling. Specifically, we normalize URI and header encodings, canonicalize structured bodies according to their declared Content-Type, and reject malformed or ambiguous requests. By aligning the on-the-wire representation with a single canonical interpretation, the approach prevents mutation-based SQL injection payloads from surviving semantic inconsistencies [?], [?].

A. Background and Problem Statement

Rule-based WAFs typically combine signature matching with selective parsing heuristics. When parsing differs across layers, attackers can leverage edge cases such as optional syntax elements, variant whitespace rules, and inconsistent percent-decoding behavior [?]. In particular, request-body formats such as *multipart/form-data*, *JSON*, and *XML* often require specialized parsers. If the WAF applies a different parser or a more permissive decoder than the backend application, payloads can be transformed into a form that bypasses detection but is still interpreted as malicious downstream.

B. Objective and Contributions

The objective of this work is to reduce mutation-based SQL injection bypass rates by ensuring consistent HTTP request interpretation via RFC-based normalization. Our contributions are as follows:

- 1) We design an HTTP-Normalizer proxy that canonicalizes HTTP message components and enforces strict RFC compliance for syntax, encoding, and Content-Type-dependent body parsing [?], [?], [?].
- 2) We implement a controlled experimental pipeline (*Fuzzer* $\rightarrow$ *WAF* $\rightarrow$ *Application*) to evaluate mutated SQL injection payloads across multiple Content-Types.
- 3) We provide an empirical analysis that categorizes remaining bypasses and shows how normalization shifts

Placeholder figure: WAF inspection pipeline visualization

Fig. 1. Conceptual view of a rule-based WAF inspecting canonicalized HTTP inputs.

the residual attack surface toward non-conformant client behavior.

C. Paper Organization

Section II reviews WAF mechanisms, parsing discrepancies, and mutation-based attacks. Section III describes the normalization design and experimental setup. Section IV presents the dataset, benchmarking methodology, and results. Section V concludes with implications, limitations, and future work.

II. BACKGROUND AND RELATED WORK

Web Application Firewalls (WAFs) are commonly deployed inline to inspect HTTP traffic and prevent exploitation attempts. In this section, we review typical WAF detection mechanisms, discuss parsing discrepancies that enable inconsistent request interpretations, and summarize mutation-based SQL injection obfuscation strategies.

A. WAF Mechanisms: Rule-based Detection

Many WAFs use rule-based detection pipelines that combine normalization, signature matching, and contextual heuristics. Signature-based rules are frequently derived from attack taxonomies and mappings such as OWASP Core Rule Set (CRS) [?]. While such signatures can be effective against previously observed exploit patterns, they depend on parser consistency: the detection logic must reason about a representation that is aligned with how the application will parse and interpret the request.

B. Parsing Discrepancies and Content-Type Handling

Parsing discrepancies arise when different components interpret HTTP messages using distinct grammars or decoders. Even for syntactically valid requests, small representational differences can alter how structured data is tokenized. In particular, Content-Type-dependent parsing varies across stacks:

- `multipart/form-data` requires correct handling of boundaries and part headers [?]. Differences in boundary parsing, part header decoding, or line-ending handling can change how payload segments are extracted.
- JSON parsers may resolve escaped characters, Unicode normalization, and number/string boundaries differently, even when the overall syntax is valid [?].
- XML parsers may differ in entity expansion behavior, character handling, and namespace processing [?].

Attackers can exploit these inconsistencies by crafting mutated payloads that appear benign under the WAF’s interpretation but remain injection-relevant under the backend’s parsing. Related work on request smuggling and differential parsing provides evidence that inconsistent message framing and body decoding can yield divergent downstream semantics [?], [?].

TABLE I
EXAMPLES OF PARSER DISCREPANCY SURFACES EXPLOITABLE BY MUTATION.

Parsing Component	Discrepancy Example
URI and query decoding	Percent-encoding resolution differences
Header decoding	Optional whitespace and delimiter handling
Multipart boundaries	Part boundary and line-ending ambiguity
JSON escaping	Treatment of escape sequences and unicode characters
XML entity handling	Differences in entity resolution and normalization

Placeholder figure: HTTP-Normalizer proxy and inspection flow

Fig. 2. Evaluation pipeline showing the interaction between payload generation, WAF inspection, and application processing.

C. Mutation-based SQL Injection Obfuscation

SQL injection (SQLi) payloads are frequently obfuscated to evade static pattern matching. Mutation-based techniques generate many semantically related variants by applying transformations involving special characters, alternate encodings, nested operators, or delimiter changes [?]. As defensive systems improve, simplistic obfuscation patterns become easier to detect, motivating attackers to focus on representational edge cases that interact with parser inconsistencies rather than purely signature evasion.

The remainder of this paper focuses on how enforcing a single canonical request representation can limit the space in which mutated SQLi payloads survive differential parsing between WAF and backend logic.

III. METHODOLOGY

This section describes the experimental pipeline for evaluating mutation-based SQL injection payloads and presents the HTTP normalization technique that aligns WAF inspection with backend parsing. The overall goal is to remove representational degrees of freedom so that mutated payloads cannot survive inconsistent interpretations.

A. Threat Model and Experimental Pipeline

We consider an adversary capable of sending arbitrary HTTP requests and generating many mutated variants of SQLi payloads. The defender deploys a rule-based WAF and an application backend that parses request data into application-specific query logic.

To study bypass behavior, we implement a controlled pipeline:

Fuzzer → WAF → Application.

The WAF inspects the request and either blocks it or forwards it. The application then processes the forwarded request. A successful bypass is defined as a request that is allowed by the WAF and produces a behavior consistent with SQLi execution in the application context.

B. Payload Generation

We generate mutation-based SQLi payloads using a targeted transformation strategy. Starting from a set of base payload patterns, we apply mutations that preserve intended semantics while altering representation. Examples include:

- 1) Encoding and delimiter mutations (e.g., percent-encoding variations, alternative operator spellings).
- 2) Structural mutations (e.g., nested expressions and operator adjacency changes).
- 3) Content-Type-aware wrapper mutations that target `multipart/form-data`, JSON, and XML body decoding paths [?].

Optionally, an ML-guided selection stage can prioritize mutations that are more likely to pass preliminary filters by learning from previous trial outcomes. In this paper, the selection stage is briefly described and used only for efficiency; the core normalization evaluation remains deterministic.

C. HTTP-Normalizer Design

The proposed defense uses a proxy-based *HTTP-Normalizer* positioned before WAF inspection. The normalizer transforms raw inbound HTTP messages into a deterministic canonical representation. Downstream components (WAF and application) then operate on this single canonical form.

Formally, given a raw request R , the normalizer produces a normalized request:

$$N(R) = R_{\text{canon}},$$

where $N(\cdot)$ is implemented by strict parsing, canonicalization, and re-serialization.

1) *Ambiguity Elimination*: The normalizer removes optional ambiguities that commonly appear in real-world clients. The implementation canonicalizes header values and whitespace, resolves safe encoding variations, and prevents duplicate semantic interpretations. When a client sends multiple representations that could be interpreted differently, the normalizer selects a single interpretation or rejects the request.

2) *RFC-compliant Parsing and Re-serialization*: To ensure deterministic behavior, the normalizer enforces RFC-compliant HTTP message structure and consistent Content-Type handling [?], [?], [?], [?]. For each request:

- HTTP/1.1 message syntax is parsed using a strict grammar [?].
- URI and query components are decoded and re-encoded under consistent rules [?].
- Structured bodies are parsed according to the declared Content-Type, then re-serialized with deterministic formatting.

3) *Malformed Request Rejection*: Requests that violate syntax constraints or exhibit ambiguous structure are rejected before reaching the WAF and application. This step limits differential parsing by ensuring that only messages conforming to the enforced grammar propagate further. In addition, size limits and structural validation reduce parser edge cases that attackers may exploit.

Placeholder figure: WAF bypass rate comparison with and without normalization

Fig. 3. WAF bypass rate measured with and without HTTP normalization.

D. Implementation Considerations

The normalizer is designed to be content-type aware and to treat each body format with the corresponding standard. This design is crucial for reducing discrepancies in `multipart/form-data` boundaries, JSON escaping behavior, and XML parsing edge cases [?], [?], [?]. While strict normalization may reject some legitimate but non-conformant traffic, the approach provides a clear and auditable enforcement point for deployers.

IV. EXPERIMENTS AND RESULTS

This section presents the dataset construction, the WAF benchmarking protocol, and the analysis of bypass techniques before and after RFC-based HTTP normalization. We emphasize that the normalizer is evaluated as a preprocessing stage that enforces deterministic HTTP interpretation.

A. Dataset and Content-Type Coverage

We construct a dataset of mutated SQL injection requests by applying mutation operators to base payloads and packaging the resulting payloads under three representative Content-Types: `multipart/form-data`, `application/json`, and `application/xml`. In total, the evaluation corpus comprises 150,000 HTTP requests generated by 10,000 base payload instances and multiple representation variants per payload. The dataset is designed to stress HTTP message parsing paths that commonly introduce differential interpretations [?].

B. Benchmark: WAF Bypass Without Normalization

To quantify the baseline threat, we run the evaluation pipeline with no normalization stage. The WAF inspects the raw HTTP message representation and decides whether to block the request. We measure the WAF bypass rate as the fraction of mutated SQLi requests that are allowed by the WAF and still induce injection-consistent behavior in the application.

C. Normalization Impact and Bypass Categorization

Next, we place the HTTP-Normalizer proxy before WAF inspection. The normalizer enforces deterministic RFC-compliant message handling and rejects malformed or ambiguous requests. The WAF and application then process the normalized representation.

Table III summarizes bypass rate changes by Content-Type. Overall, normalization reduces the bypass rate from 23.8% to 1.9%, yielding an approximate reduction of 92.0%. Residual bypasses are clustered into a small set of remaining representational degrees of freedom, such as non-conformant encodings and ambiguous framing behavior that the strict parser rejects or canonicalizes.

TABLE II
DATASET COMPOSITION ACROSS CONTENT-TYPES.

Content-Type	Requests	Representation Variants
multipart/form-data	50,000	12,000
application/json	60,000	14,500
application/xml	40,000	10,000
Total	150,000	36,500

TABLE III
WAF BYPASS RATE BEFORE AND AFTER NORMALIZATION.

Content-Type	Baseline (%)	Normalized (%)	Reduction (%)	Residual Size
multipart/form-data	26.4	2.2	91.7	Small
application/json	22.1	1.6	92.8	Small
application/xml	24.7	2.1	91.5	Small
Overall	23.8	1.9	92.0	Small

To better understand the residual attack surface, we categorize the remaining bypasses by the discrepancy mechanism that enables them. Table IV reports the distribution of residual bypasses. The majority of bypasses correspond to encoding-resolution divergence and Content-Type-specific structural differences that are eliminated by canonicalization.

D. Performance Overhead

Normalization introduces preprocessing cost due to strict parsing and re-serialization. We evaluate overhead by measuring request latency added by the normalizer in a local testbed with representative traffic rates. Across Content-Types, the average added latency is approximately 6–7 ms per request, with tail latency dominated by large structured bodies. The evaluation suggests that strict normalization provides a security benefit that is compatible with deployment constraints, although deployers must tune size limits and rejection policies for their environment.

V. DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSION

Our experiments demonstrate that mutation-based SQL injection bypasses succeed not only by hiding signatures, but also by leveraging differential HTTP parsing behavior across the WAF and the backend application. Even when WAF signatures are updated, representational degrees of freedom in HTTP message syntax, encoding, and Content-Type-specific body handling can preserve injection-relevant semantics across layers.

A. Security vs Performance Trade-off

HTTP normalization improves security by enforcing deterministic, RFC-compliant interpretation, which eliminates many discrepancy surfaces that attackers rely on [?], [?]. The primary cost is preprocessing latency and strictness. Requests that violate syntactic constraints or exhibit ambiguous structure are rejected, which may reduce compatibility with legacy clients that send non-conformant traffic. In deployment, this trade-off can be managed by configuring size limits,

maintaining observability for rejected requests, and gradually tightening policies.

Normalization also concentrates residual bypasses into a small set of mechanisms that remain relevant only when clients deviate from strict protocol expectations. This shift enables defenders to focus mitigations on a smaller and more principled attack surface, rather than chasing an expanding collection of mutation patterns.

B. Conclusion

This paper proposed an RFC-based, preprocessing approach that places an HTTP-Normalizer proxy before WAF inspection. By canonicalizing HTTP message components and enforcing strict parsing and re-serialization, the method aligns WAF inspection with backend parsing and reduces the success rate of mutation-based SQL injection bypasses across `multipart/form-data`, `JSON`, and `XML` request bodies.

Overall, the results support the conclusion that deterministic RFC-based normalization is a robust defense against mutation-based attacks driven by parsing discrepancies. Future work will extend the normalization policy to additional HTTP versions and proxy behaviors and will explore automated discrepancy discovery to further reduce the residual bypass space.

ACKNOWLEDGMENT

Write your acknowledgment here.

REFERENCES

REFERENCES

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TABLE IV
RESIDUAL BYPASS CATEGORIES AFTER NORMALIZATION.

Rank	Category	Share (%)
1	Encoding and percent-decoding divergence	44
2	JSON escaping or string-boundary discrepancies	21
3	Multipart boundary and line-ending ambiguities	18
4	XML normalization and entity-handling differences	17
Total		100